

Session 35: Reflecting on Jonah's Prayer

Key Takeaways

- Jonah is so self-consumed that he doesn't realize he's self-consumed.
- Jonah perceives the sailors as the idolators, but Jonah's actions recall the rebellious Israelites who made the golden calf. He's trying to make his own paradise, and he's greedy for a life without God.
- Jonah's prayer deepens the mystery of his character and motives, and that's okay.
- Every line of the prayer poem comes from the Psalms with subtle tweaks.

Oddities and Observations About Jonah's Poem

The image of a prophet composing a poem in the belly of a beast is odd, but so is the prayer's content. Why is it a thanksgiving for deliverance instead of a confession of guilt or a plea to be released from the fish?

The prayer is a thanksgiving for a rescue that has already happened, though it seems that Jonah is still in danger of death by a monster. But notice that the great fish is actually the vehicle of salvation from death and the underworld. Jonah describes his peril as death by drowning, not by fish digestion.

The tone of Jonah's words (praise, gratefulness, humility) contrasts his oblivious hypocrisy ([Jon. 1:9](#)) and self-consumed anger ([Jon. 4](#)) elsewhere in the book.

"These two Jonah figures [the rebel of chs. 1, 3, and 4; and the grateful of ch. 2] ... do not simply separate into two. It is quite possible that the righteous one enters into the disobedient one and lends him his voice. And when such thanksgiving, strange though it be, comes from lips that are otherwise impious—even when that praise is seriously contradicted by the life of the person in question who does not, perhaps, really understand at all what he is saying—there the sun of divine comfort does shine, even though behind clouds."

von Rad, Gerhard (1980). [God at Work in Israel](#). Abingdon. 70.

"[I]n the context of chapter 1 and the remainder of the book it can only be seen as another inappropriate, hypocritical, pious-sounding affirmation like 1:9 before it and 4:2 after it. By it, Jonah shows the reader more clearly his true colors. His phrases sound good and right, but in the event they turn out to be empty. The negative character portrayal of Jonah in chapter 1 is sharpened in 2, as he is further and further separated from those around him by his appalling behavior. This separation is not complete until the book's end, where Jonah is in fact physically separated from everyone."

Holbert, John (1981). "Deliverance Belongs to Yahweh!: Satire in the Book of Jonah." *Journal for the Study of the Old Testament*, vol. 6 (21). 74-75.

“The psalm does present Jonah as an orthodox and pious Yahwist who responds to salvation with appropriate thanksgiving. Through its vivid description of the experience and emotions of drowning, it provides readers intimate insight into Jonah’s thoughts and feelings, thereby casting him in a more sympathetic light. Simultaneously the context highlights Jonah’s lack of reflection on his conflict with Yahweh. The tension between the sympathetic portrait in the psalm and the judgment implied by the book as a whole is acute, but not inherently contradictory. The psalm simply elicits reader identification with Jonah to such a degree that the confrontation with Jonah’s true motivations in ch. 4 forces them to share his discomfort.”

Watts, James W. (1992). [Psalm and Story: Inset Hymns in Hebrew Narrative](#). A&C Black. 139.

Key Hyperlinked Psalms in Jonah’s Prayer

Nearly every line in Jonah’s prayer has been adapted from poems throughout the book of Psalms. In each case, an image of danger, death, or exile has been associated with Jonah sinking into the sea.

Jonah	Psalms
I called out from my distress to Yahweh and he answered me. From the belly of the fish I shouted for help and you heard my voice.	120:1: To Yahweh in my distress I called, and he answered me. 31:22b: You heard the voice of plea when I shouted to you for help.
And you cast me to the deep, to the heart of the seas. And a river surrounded me. All your waves and breakers passed over me.	102:10: You lifted me up and cast me away. Exodus 15:8: At the wind of your nostrils, waters congealed ... deep in the heart of the sea. 42:7: All your waves and breakers passed over me.
And I said: I am banished from before your eyes. However, I will continue to gaze to your holy temple.	31:22a: And as for me, I said, I am cut off from before your eyes. 138:2: I will bow toward your holy temple.
The waters encircled me up to the neck. The deep surrounded me. Kelp wrapped to my head, to the base of the mountains I went down. The underworld, its bars around me, forever.	18:4, 116:3: Cords of death encircled me. 69:2: The waters ... up to my neck. 103:4: He redeems my life from the pit.

Hyperlinked Psalms in Jonah’s Prayer. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Jonah	Psalms
But you raise up my life from the pit, Yahweh my God.	
When my being was fainting within me, I remembered Yahweh. And my prayer came to you, to your holy temple.	143:4-5: When my spirit was fainting within me ... I remember. 88:2: May my prayer come before you.
Those who keep idols of worthlessness forsake the covenant love shown them. But I, with a voice of thanksgiving, I will sacrifice to you. What I have vowed I will pay in full. Rescue belongs to Yahweh!	31:6: I hate those who keep idols of worthlessness, but I ... rejoice in your covenant love. 116:17-18: To you I will offer a sacrifice of thanksgiving ... I will pay my vows. 3:8: Rescue belongs to Yahweh!
<i>Hyperlinked Psalms in Jonah's Prayer. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).</i>	

Because we can trace the source texts, Jonah's prayer provides a fascinating window into the methods of biblical composition.

The poem's opening line is adapted from Psalm 120:1

Psalm 120:1 Instructor's Translation

To Yahweh **in** my distress I called
and he answered me

Jonah 2:2 Instructor's Translation

I called **from** my distress Yahweh
and he answered me

The word order has been changed so that in Jonah 2, the speaker's call to Yahweh is now emphasized by being placed at the beginning.

The prepositional phrase has been adapted from "**in** my distress" (לי בצרתה) to "**from** my distress" (הדגה ממעי) and aligned with the context as Jonah prays "from the innards of the fish" (לי מצרה) and cries out "from the belly of the grave" (שואל מבטן). (Magonet, *Form and Meaning*, 47).

Jonah 2:3	Source Texts
And you cast me into the deep (מצולה),	Exodus 15:4 Pharaoh's chariots and his army he has cast into the sea; and the choicest of his officers are drowned in the Sea of Reeds. Psalms 102:10 Because of your indignation and your wrath, for you have lifted me up and you cast me away (מפני־זעמך וקצפך כי נשאתני ותשליכני). Psalms 69:15 Don't let the flood of water overflow me and don't let the deep (מצולה) swallow me up nor the pit shut its mouth on me.
Into the heart of the seas ,	Exodus 15:8 At the blast of your nostrils the waters piled up ... the deeps congealed in the heart of the seas. Ezekiel 27:4, 25-27; 28:2, 8 All applied to Tyre
And the river surrounded me.	Genesis 2:10-14 The river of Eden surrounds Havilah and Cush
All your breakers and billows passed over me .	Psalms 42:6-7 O my God, my soul is in despair within me; therefore I remember you from the land of the Jordan and the peaks of Hermon, from Mount Mizar. Deep calls to deep at the sound of your waterfalls; all your breakers and your waves have rolled over me.
Source Texts in Scripture for Jonah 2:3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).	

Notice how images of the defeat of Pharaoh in the seas (Exod. 15) have been adapted into imagery to describe a personal crisis (Ps. 102, 69), the downfall of a city (Tyre in Ezek. 27), and the exile from the Jerusalem temple (Ps. 42).

Jonah 2:4

Jonah 2:4 NASB*

As for me, I said: I am **banished**
from before Yahweh.
Nevertheless ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 31:22 NASB*

And as for me I said **in my alarm**
I am **cut off** from before Yahweh.
Nevertheless ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Note that this line adapts Psalm 31:22 verbatim, except for the phrase “in my alarm.” The absence of “in my alarm” (בַּחֲפוּזִי) from Psalm 31:22 can be explained as unnecessary to the author’s portrayal of Jonah. In Psalm 31:22, the poet portrays his distress as one in a city under siege, which causes alarm until he calls out for deliverance. In Jonah 2, Jonah’s inner-shift of orientation only happens after his total “descent” into death, which has not yet happened in the sequence of the poem.

The replacement of “I am cut off” with “I am banished” (נִגְרָשְׁתִּי) ties Jonah’s descent into the exile pattern based on [Genesis 3-4](#).

Jonah 2:5

Jonah 2:5 NASB*

Waters have encompassed me unto my neck.
The deep has surrounded me,
reeds bound to my head.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The author has brought together phrases from multiple texts.

“They have encompassed me” (אֶפְסוּנִי) comes from either Psalm 18:4 or [116:3](#).

Psalm 18:4-5 NASB*

⁴ The cords of death encompassed me;
the torrents of destruction overwhelmed me.
⁵ The cords of the grave surrounded me;
the snares of death confronted me.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“Waters ... unto my neck” comes from Psalm 69:2.

Psalm 69:1-2 NASB*

¹ Save me, O God,
for the waters have come up to my neck.
² I have sunk in mire of the deep, and there is no foothold.
I have come into deep waters, and a flood overflows me.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The composition of Jonah 2:5 is a combination of two distinct texts, Psalms 18 and 69.

Psalms 18:4 NASB

The cords of death **have encompassed me**;

Psalms 69:1 NIV

For **the waters** have come **up to my neck**,

Jonah 2:5 NASB*

... have encompassed me
waters ... up to my neck

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

But why the avoidance of the phrase “cords of death” in Psalm 18:4? Though the word “death” may seem appropriate to this poem, this word would be out of place as it seems to be a key word restricted to the final chapter of Jonah. Although Jonah has approached symbolic death and implied that he wished to die by being cast overboard, it is still too soon in the writer’s purpose to spell out the prophet’s wish, for it would destroy the tension in his argument with God in chapter 4.

Jonah 2:8 Instructor's Translation

Those who keep empty idols abandon the covenant love of them.

What does “empty idols” (שוא הבל) mean? Both words are associated with derogatory vocabulary for idols, asserting their inability to help because they are only statues and not deities.

Zechariah 10:2 Instructor's Translation

For idols speak deceit,
and diviners conjure lies,
and dreams speak falsehood (שוא);
they offer empty (הבל) comfort.

Deuteronomy 32:21 Instructor's Translation

They ignited my passion with what is not-god,
they provoked me with their nothings (הבל).

Covenant Loyalty

What about “their covenant loyalty” (חסדם)? The third-person masculine plural suffix on “their covenant love” could be subjective or objective.

Subjective

Their covenant love toward God: Maintaining allegiance to idols is a violation of one’s covenant obligations toward God.

“[I]dols represent not only ineffectiveness; worshiping them also shows a lack of faith in Yahweh. For any Israelite to trust in idol worship was a violation of the covenant. Covenant loyalty (חסד) was a mutual obligation both of God, the initiator of the covenant (Exod 20:6, etc.), and of the Israelites to whom the covenant was given. Accordingly, one who broke the covenant’s first commandment by having other gods had ‘abandoned’ (עזב) his or her loyalty to Yahweh.”

Stuart, Douglas (1987). *Word Biblical Commentary Vol. 31, Hosea-Jonah*. Thomas Nelson Inc. 478.

Objective

God’s covenant love toward them: Giving allegiance to idols forfeits the divine covenant commitment that God shows to his faithful people.

“Here (חסד), ‘steadfast love,’ does not mean human faithfulness. It means the divine attitude which in the Psalter is continually extolled as God’s faithfulness, goodness, and graciousness, which is the one true help for human beings. The third person plural suffix does not refer to the subject of the faithfulness; it means its object (cf. Ps. 59:17*; 144:2*), i.e., those to whom the dependable help is given. In 4:2* חסד, as almost always, is one of the divine attributes.”

Wolff, Hans Walter (1986). [*Obadiah and Jonah: A Commentary*](#). Augsburg Fortress Pub. 138.

The source of the quotation in Psalm 31:7 clarifies that “God’s covenant loyalty” is likely in view (the “objective” view).

Psalm 31:6-7 NIV*

⁶ **I hate those who keep worthless idols;**
and as for me I trust in Yahweh.
⁷ I rejoice and am glad in **your covenant loyalty**,
for you have seen my affliction
you have known my distress.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah 2:8-9 NASB*

⁸ **Those who keep hold of worthless idols**
abandon their **covenant loyalty**,
⁹ **and as for me**, I will sacrifice to you
with a voice of thanksgiving.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"This statement by the poet at this point ... must be a summation of his experience and the lesson he has learned from it ... Yet the sentence by itself, a generalized impersonal statement about the fate of those who 'regard lying vanities' tells us nothing ... The sentence surprises us by its appearance, and puzzles us by having no obvious relationship to the experience described in the poem. So we are forced to go to the only other place where an answer might lie, namely the original source of the phrase in Psalm 31. And here we have a clue in the form of a first person statement: 'I hate,' which is significantly absent in our poem. We are thus led to conclude that the speaker in our poem no longer hates the worshippers of idols but accepts instead that if they continue to regard their idols (the Piel form suggesting a repeated action or a more intense form of attachment), then they will ultimately exhaust the mercy which is bestowed upon them by God, they will forsake their $\tau\omicron\eta\eta$. Thus, the speaker has come to accept a more tolerant, though still rather grudging, view of idolators."

Magonet, Jonathan (1983). [*Form and Meaning: Studies in Literary Techniques in the Book of Jonah*](#). Almond Press. 46.

"To ally oneself with idols is folly, for they can give no help. Other gods are contemptuously dismissed as useless idols, worthless nonentities. The contrast in ch. 1 between the ineffectual prayer each to his own god and the answered prayer to Yahweh, sovereign over the sea, is echoed in the declaration and denial of vv. 7, 8. In its original setting this section of the psalm envisaged Israelites who betrayed the covenant by resorting to the worship of other gods, and recorded the speaker's dissociation from them in a profession of complete loyalty and so accessibility to Yahweh's favor. Cutting themselves off from Yahweh's aid, they only 'multiply their sorrows' (Ps. 16:4). His grace, the loyal love that rushes to the aid of his own at their first cry, in the psalm's present context not only glances back to Jonah's deliverance but hints at that of the sailors who abandoned their own gods and relied upon Yahweh. This hint is to be taken up in ch. 4."

Allen, Leslie C. (1976). [*The Books of Joel, Obadiah, Jonah, and Micah*](#). Eerdmans. 218-219.

Reflection Question

What do you make of Jonah's prayer? Is he sincere or hypocritical? Is this even the point the author is trying to make?